

WRITING FOR A CREW OF FOUR

Scenes from the shipped script, set from the game's dialogue files. Margins note the design intent.

THE SCRIPT FORMAT

Dialogue is written as plain text for a writer, not in code: nodes (`=== camp`), lines (`Vesper: ...`), choices (`? text -> node`), conditions (`[if camp-rystak]`), story flags, word lessons (`@learn Mur`) and world events (`@event touch`). A line may carry a **Conceptual Bleed** variant after `||`, which Lyssia speaks after the Touch.

Tests check every referenced node exists and every branch is reachable. Every line is voiced, rendered offline from this same text.

SPEAKER	LINES
LYSSIA	102
VESPER	66
CAELUS	63
RYSTAK	59
NARRATOR	24
Choices	33
Bleed variants	17
Nodes	102

THE RULES I WROTE BY

- **Every scene changes something:** a fact learned, a relationship moved, a rule taught.
- **Subtext over statement:** characters talk around what matters.
- **Jokes with a job:** humour carries the lore, and a joke should say something about who tells it.
- **One rule, said plainly once:** the second time, a companion restates it in their own voice.
- **Write for the ear:** every line is voiced; "..." is a held pause, full stops are beats.



The campfire: the one quiet scene of the chapter, and the setup for the Black Mirror.

VESPER Dead end.

LYSSIA Not a dead end. A mirror.

VESPER A lock, then. No keyhole. No tumblers. I can't pick a reflection.

CAELUS Allow me. This is clearly a Proximity Ward. It requires a signature of high divinity.

CAELUS I, Caelus the Sky-Walker, Commander of the Twelfth House, demand passage! Open, in the name of the Council!

▸ the glyph spins faster

A puff of sparkling flash-powder. A burst of magnetic force. The glyph only spins faster.

RYSTAK Impressive. You made it angry.

CAELUS It's archaic tech! My output is calibrated for Modern Era locks, not this... prehistoric junk.

LYSSIA It's not junk, Caelus. It's a question.

LYSSIA The glyph is Kha'shul. It creates a loop. It asks whoever looks into it to define themselves against the void.

LYSSIA This shape keeps coming back, the circle at its heart. The self. The one who speaks.

learns **Sael** (the self, the speaker)

VESPER So what do we say? Friend? Guest?

LYSSIA Kha'shul has no word for "friend". It deals in absolutes.

LYSSIA It asks: "What survives the fire?"

CHARACTER IN ONE BEAT

Caelus's god-voice fails on archaic tech. Rystak's deadpan (*You made it angry*) and Caelus's excuse establish both men before the puzzle starts.

TEACHING

Lyssia learns **SAEL** here, the word the wrong answer needs, so the player can try **GHAR-SAEL** (I remain) and be refused.

THEME STATED ONCE

Kha'shul has no word for friend is the manuscript's line. It was planted at the campfire the night before, so here it lands as an echo.

*if mirror-guessed**The glyph keeps turning. What survives the fire?*

- ? Rystak says: "Steel." → mirror-steel
- ? Caelus says: "Gold." → mirror-gold
- ? Vesper says: "Nothing." → mirror-nothing
- ? The answer isn't a thing. → mirror-state

RYSTAK Steel. Obviously.

▸ the glyph flares red

LYSSIA Steel melts, Rystak. They made your axe in a fire.**LYSSIA** *if camp-rystak* Last night you told me something else survives it.**RYSTAK** *if camp-rystak* Scars don't open doors, Scholar.**RYSTAK** *if !camp-rystak* My axe is not a philosophical argument.**CAELUS** Gold. Gold is eternal. Ask any god.

▸ the glyph flares red

LYSSIA Gold melts too. So does paint.**CAELUS** *if camp-caelus* ...That was low, Scholar. You were listening last night.**CAELUS** *if !camp-caelus* It is a very expensive face paint.**VESPER** Nothing. Nothing survives the fire.

▸ the glyph flares red

LYSSIA *if camp-vesper* And yet you're saving for a door.**VESPER** *if camp-vesper* A door isn't hope, Scholar. It's a precaution.**LYSSIA** *if !camp-vesper* Then why guard the door with the question?**VESPER** *if !camp-vesper* Because it's a trap. Everything is a trap.**LYSSIA** I remember the fire at the Academy. The Dean threw my thesis into the grate. "Heresy," he said.**LYSSIA** The paper was gone. The ink was gone. But the idea... the idea remained.**LYSSIA** The answer isn't a thing. It's a state of being.**LYSSIA** And it has to be said the way the Ancients said everything. As a fact.**A CHOICE THAT ISN'T A GUESS**

The crew's three answers are the chapter's (Steel, Gold, Nothing). Each is refused, and each refusal gets its own reaction: wrong answers are content.

CALLBACKS

Lines marked *if camp-** only play if the player sat with that companion at the fire the night before. Rystak said *scars*; Vesper wanted *a door*; Caelus kept his *paint*. The Mirror brings each answer back to its owner.

THE TURN

The last option is not an answer but a realisation. Lyssia remembers the Dean's grate, and the player composes **GHAR-OTH** from the first two words they ever copied.

Dusk thickens into night. The Mouth is a darker shape against the dark, and nobody looks at it for long.

RYSTAK Eat. Then sleep. Then we don't talk about the face.

CAELUS It's a statue, Rystak. A large, rude statue.

RYSTAK It was looking at you.

CAELUS It was looking at everyone. That's what makes it rude.

The whetstone goes along the blade, and back, and along it again.

LYSSIA Why "Widow-Maker"?

RYSTAK Didn't name it. The man I took it from did. He'd earned the name.

RYSTAK I'm still paying it off.

LYSSIA You swear by the fire. "By the Fire." I've heard you.

RYSTAK Where I come from, you swear by what can't take anything back. Fire doesn't lie about what it's done.

? "What survives it?" → camp-rystak-survives

? "You're a better man than you let on." → camp-rystak-better

He stops sharpening. For a while there is only the fire.

RYSTAK Scars. Scars survive. The rest is ash.

RYSTAK Go to sleep, Scholar.

LYSSIA'S LAST WATCH *the camp, late*

One by one, they sleep. Rystak last, the axe across his knees. Lyssia doesn't sleep at all.

The fire takes a branch, slowly, the way the Dean's grate took her thesis. Three years of ink. Under a minute.

LYSSIA The paper went. The ink went.

LYSSIA I still know every word.

LYSSIA Kha'shul has no word for "friend". It deals in absolutes.

AFTER THE TOUCH: *Kha'shul has no word for "friend". Maybe it never needed one.*

The fire burns low. Past the trees, the Mouth of Silence keeps its patience.

WHY A CAMP

Pacing: the only quiet scene between the jungle and the Throat. Vesper refuses to enter the Mouth in the dark, so the rest is motivated, not arbitrary.

ONE QUESTION, THREE ANSWERS

Each companion answers *what survives the fire?* without being asked. The player chooses whom to sit with; the Mirror will remember.

SUBTEXT

Rystak never says why he's paying off the axe. *That's what armour's for. So nobody has to find out the rest.*

SETUP AND PAYOFF

The Dean's fire is planted here, in narration, the night before the Mirror asks about fire. The line about *friend* is the manuscript's; the Bleed variant answers it.

VESPER We are clear. Grab it and let's go. I can hear things moving in the walls.

LYSSIA It's cold. So cold it hurts to breathe.

LYSSIA The script isn't embossed. It's sunken, like scars. And it pulses. Thump-thump. Thump-thump.

LYSSIA It's not a book. It's a containment vessel.

RYSTAK Bag it! The gears are speeding up!

She knows she should use her gloves. She knows she should use the tongs Caelus built. But a voice, like wind howling through a canyon, whispers: Touch.

? Use the gloves. → verses-gloves
? Use Caelus's tongs. → verses-tongs
? Touch. → verses-touch

She lays her bare hand on the black leather.

▸ the vision plays

RYSTAK Lyssia!

LYSSIA I heard it. A voice. It said...

AFTER THE TOUCH: *I heard the door. It was holding its breath.*

CAELUS My fork! The tines shattered! That pulse... you just rang the dinner bell for every Warden in the hemisphere!

▸ the ceiling cracks; Sentinels detach

VESPER Constructs! They're waking up!

VESPER The door! Run!

▸ the door reforms, glyph red

VESPER Blocked. The metal's reformed and the glyph's gone red. It's a lockdown.

RYSTAK Lyssia, let go of the book!

LYSSIA I can't. It's heavy. My hand won't open.

AFTER THE TOUCH: *It is heavier than the island. My hand has forgotten how to open.*

RYSTAK Caelus! Do something god-like!

CAELUS My illusions won't work on constructs! They don't have eyes to deceive!

RYSTAK Then stop lying and start destroying! Use the Sun-Sphere!

[the scene continues into the escape]

A CHOICE THAT CAN'T BE MADE

Gloves, tongs or touch: every option ends in the touch, which is the book's point. The first two get a line each, so the choice still feels heard.

CONCEPTUAL BLEED

From here Lyssia's lines switch to their variants (violet): the language starts speaking through her. The crew notices before she does.

EVENTS IN THE SCRIPT

World beats (@event) sit in the dialogue itself, so the writer paces the vision, the ceiling cracking and the lockdown line by line.